The Late Market — a judge's guide

Siki & Zana · Zoud GameLab, “Make FinLit Fun” · ~10–15 minutes · free in your browser

> **What this is:** a financial-literature game where the player's own decisions become the experiment. You run a small business through one week; the game silently runs behavioural experiments on you, then reads your decisions back as data. Built by the team behind a working receivables product — the game's arithmetic is pinned to production code in CI, and every figure is audited in public.

What to look for (three things)

- **The paired-choice experiment (Chapter 1).** Day 3 and Day 5 ask structurally identical questions — chase now vs defer — with identical numbers. Only the frame moved. Watch whether your answer moves with it, and whether the debrief names the bias on *your* figures, not a textbook's.
- **The anchor manipulation (Chapter 2).** Three negotiation runs, three different opening numbers, one invoice whose facts never change. Name your floor and watch it shift toward their anchor. The debrief graphs your floor against their number.
- **The audited arithmetic.** Every number in the game is either a real statutory figure (UK Late Payment of Commercial Debts Act 1998, s.5A — 8% over base + fixed compensation) or a labelled fictional/indicative one. The audit appendix maps each figure to its source and the test that guards it — linked from the game footer.

How to play it well

- **Two markets, one instrument.** The title screen (or first-run picker) offers London (pounds, statutory interest) and **The Souq** (dirhams, a contractual late fee you wrote into your own terms — plus zakat on uncollected receivables). Same week, same arithmetic, two lawful remedies. The Souq path carries Arabic script (السوق · الزكاة) — the instrument is interest-free, so the game prices lateness differently on purpose, not by translation.
- **Read the ledger, not just the till.** Every deferral is written to a visible ledger and lights a stall on the street. The street is the shadow market your lateness feeds — it is the game's central metaphor, not decoration.
- **The ending is the point.** The finale reads your whole decision ledger back, names what moved you, and hands you a link into the real product the game teaches. Replay is scored on your Rationality Delta.

Honest limits (stated in-game too)

- One playthrough is a demonstration, not an experiment — the game says so on the debrief. The paired decisions show you *your* choice under two frames.
- Fictional offers are labelled fictional; indicative ranges are labelled indicative. No provider is named or recommended; the game never moves money.
- Audio is optional; every line is subtitled. Simple-language mode, adjustable text size, and reduced-motion are in Options.

Artifacts: playable build (itch, private link in submission) · concept doc · budget doc · audit appendix (`docs/game/AUDIT.md`) · trailer (~105 s, both markets). Contact: Udi Robert (@udirobert).